Parent-Implemented Language Interventions

Across 25 RCTs, parent-implemented language interventions produce modest gains in expressive vocabulary for young children with or at risk for language impairment; this is not a typical-development vocabulary mandate and is not a screen-time claim.

RADE: MODERATE-EXPRESSIVE-VOCAB; LOW-UNIVERSAL-TYPICAL | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: LANGUAGE | REPLICATION: VERIFI

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Because early language is learned in caregiver–child interaction, some interventions train parents rather than only treating the child in clinic. Heidlage et al. (2020) meta-analyzed 25 RCTs (1,734 children, mean age 3.7 years) with or at risk for language impairment, including low-SES risk. Average effects: modest gains in expressive vocabulary (shared book reading g = 0.37; play/routines g = 0.50); small effects on broader expressive language; receptive language often nonsignificant. Dialogic reading (Whitehurst et al. 1988) is a named shared-book method inside that family, not a separate law.

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

RCTs of parent-implemented protocols. Efficacy under trial is not community effectiveness, scalability, or a universal parenting recipe (CONTRIBUTING.md intervention rule). Child speech is part of measured interaction; parent outcome measurement is often thin.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

Hedges g in the small-to-moderate range for expressive vocabulary in the pooled trials. Persistence beyond post-test is unevenly reported. Dialogic reading's original samples were small.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a (randomized assignment). Effects are smaller or uncertain for some autism-spectrum samples in the same meta-analysis. Families who enroll in RCTs are not all families.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Does not mean typical homes must run a language curriculum. Does not mean a missed shared book writes a life. Does not re-open Hart & Risley as a causal metric. Does not treat screen time as the inverse of these trials.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Targeted parent-implemented support for children with or at risk for language impairment is proportionate to the RCT package. Universal optimization of every toddler's vocabulary is not.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Heidlage et al. (2020), Early Childhood Research Quarterly (DOI 10.1016/j.ecresq.2018.12.006)
- Whitehurst et al. (1988), Developmental Psychology (dialogic reading)
- Gilkerson et al. (2018), Pediatrics (adjacent prediction card; not this intervention)